WIKIPEDIA 25
25 years of the free encyclopedia

Delhi

Delhi,[b] officially the **National Capital Territory** (**NCT**) **of Delhi**, is a megacity and a union territory of India containing New Delhi, the capital of India. Straddling the Yamuna river, but spread chiefly to the west, or beyond its right bank, Delhi shares borders with the state of Uttar Pradesh in the east and with the state of Haryana in the remaining directions. Delhi became a union territory on 1 November 1956 and the NCT in 1995.[24] The NCT covers an area of 1,484 square kilometres (573 sq mi).[4] According to the 2011 census, Delhi's city proper population was over 11 million,[7][25] while the NCT's population was about 16.8 million.[8]

The topography of the medieval fort Purana Qila on the banks of the river Yamuna matches the literary description of the citadel Indraprastha in the Sanskrit epic *Mahabharata*; however, excavations in the area have revealed no signs of an ancient built environment.[26] From the early 13th century until the mid-19th century, Delhi was the capital of two major empires, the Delhi Sultanate and the Mughal Empire, which covered large parts of South Asia. All three UNESCO World Heritage Sites in the city, the Qutub Minar, Humayun's Tomb, and the Red Fort, belong to this period. Delhi was the early centre of Sufism and Qawwali music. The names of Nizamuddin Auliya and Amir Khusrau are prominently associated with it. The Khariboli dialect of Delhi was part of a linguistic development that gave rise to the literature of Urdu and later Modern Standard Hindi. Major Urdu poets from Delhi include Mir Taqi Mir and Mirza Ghalib. Delhi was a notable centre of the Indian Rebellion of 1857. In 1911, New Delhi, a southern region within Delhi, became the capital of the British Indian Empire. During the Partition of India in 1947, Delhi was transformed from a Mughal city to a Punjabi one,[27][28] losing two-thirds of its Muslim residents, in part due to the pressure brought to bear by arriving Hindu and Sikh refugees from western Punjab.[29] After independence in 1947, New Delhi continued as the capital of the Dominion of India, and after 1950 of the Republic of India.

Delhi's urban agglomeration, which includes the satellite cities Ghaziabad, Faridabad, Gurgaon, Noida, Greater Noida and YEIDA city located in an area known as the National Capital Region (NCR), has an estimated population of over 28 million, making it the largest metropolitan area in India and the second-largest in the world (after Tokyo).[10] Delhi ranks fifth among the Indian states and union territories in human development index,[30] and has the second-highest GDP per capita in India (after Goa).[15] Although a union territory, the political administration of the NCT of Delhi today more closely resembles that of a state of India, with its own legislature, high court and an executive council of

Delhi

Megacity and union territory

National Capital Territory of Delhi

From top, left to right: Humayun's Tomb; Qutub Minar; Jama Masjid; Red Fort's Lahori gate; India Gate; Digambar Jain Mandir with Gauri Shankar temple in the background; St. James' Church; Hyderabad House; Lotus Temple, a Bahá'í House of Worship

Interactive map of Delhi

Coordinates: 28°36′36″N 77°13′48″E

Country	India
Region	North India
Capital, Delhi Sultanate	1214
Capital, Mughal Empire	1526, intermittently with Agra
New Delhi, capital, British Indian Empire	12 December 1911

ministers headed by a chief minister. New Delhi is jointly administered by the federal government of India and the local government of Delhi, and serves as the capital of the nation as well as the NCT of Delhi. Delhi is also the centre of the National Capital Region, which is an "interstate regional planning" area created in 1985.[31][32] Delhi hosted the inaugural 1951 Asian Games, the 1982 Asian Games, the 1983 Non-Aligned Movement summit, the 2010 Men's Hockey World Cup, the 2010 Commonwealth Games, the 2012 BRICS summit, the 2023 G20 summit, and was one of the major host cities of the 2011 and 2023 Cricket World Cups.

New Delhi, capital, Republic of India	26 January 1950
Union Territory[1][2]	1 November 1956
National Capital Territory[3]	1 February 1992
Government	
• **Body**	Government of Delhi
• **Lieutenant Governor**	Vinai Kumar Saxena
• **Chief Minister**	Rekha Gupta (BJP)
• **Legislature**	Unicameral (70 seats)
Area[4]	
• **Megacity and union territory**	1,484 km^2 (573 sq mi)
• **Water**	18 km^2 (6.9 sq mi)
• **Metro**[5][a]	3,483 km^2 (1,345 sq mi)
Elevation	200–250 m (660–820 ft)
Population (2011)[7]	
• **Megacity and union territory**	16,787,941
• **Estimate** (2024)[9]	21,588,000
• **Rank**	2nd in India 7th in Asia
• **Density**	11,312/km^2 (29,298/sq mi)
• **Urban**[8]	16,349,831 (2nd)
• **Megacity**[7]	11,034,555 (2nd)
• **Metro (2018)**[10]	28,514,000 (1st)
Languages	
• **Official**	Hindi · English[11]
• **Additional official**	Punjabi · Urdu[11]
• **Regional**	Haryanvi[12][13] · Khariboli[14]
GDP (2023–24)[15]	
• **Megacity and union territory (Nominal)**	₹1,107,746 crore (US$130 billion)[15]
• **Per Capita NSDP**	₹461,910 (US$5,500)[15]
• **Metro (Nominal)**	$273 billion[16]
• **PPP**	$521.5 billion[17]
Time zone	UTC+5.30 (IST)
PINs[20]	110000–110099
Area code	+91 11
ISO 3166 code	IN-DL
Vehicle registration	DL
International Airport	Indira Gandhi International Airport
Rapid Transit	Delhi Metro
HDI (2018)	▲ 0.839[18] (Very High) · 1st
Literacy (2011)	86.21%[19]
Sex ratio (2011)	868 ♀/1000 ♂[19]
Website	delhi.gov.in (https://delhi.gov.in/)

Toponym

There are a number of myths and legends associated with the origin of the name *Delhi*. One of them is derived from *Dhillu* or *Dilu*, a king who built a city at this location in 50 BCE and named it after himself.[33][34][35] Another legend holds that the name of the city is based on the Prakrit word *dhili* (*loose*) and that it was used by the Tomaras to refer to the city because the iron pillar of Delhi had a weak foundation and had to be moved.[35] According to Panjab Notes and Queries, the name of the city at the time of King Prithviraj was *dilpat*, and that *dilpat* and *dilli* are probably derived from the old Hindi word *dil* meaning "eminence". The former director of the Archaeological Survey of India, Alexander Cunningham, mentioned that *dilli* later became *dihli/dehli*.[36] Some suggest the coins in circulation in the region under the Tomaras were called *dehliwal*.[37] According to the Bhavishya Purana, King Prithiviraja of Indraprastha built a new fort in the modern-day Purana Qila area for the convenience of all four castes in his kingdom. He ordered the construction of a gateway to the fort and later named the fort *dehali*.[38] Some historians believe that *Dhilli* or *Dhillika* is the original name for the city while others believe the name could be a corruption of the Hindustani words *dehleez* or *dehali*—both terms meaning "threshold" or "gateway"—and symbolic of the city as a gateway to the Gangetic Plain.[39][40]

The people of Delhi are referred to as *Delhiites* or *Dilliwalas*.[41] The city is referenced in various idioms of the Northern Indo-Aryan languages. Examples include:

- *Abhī Dillī dūr hai* (अभी दिल्ली दूर है / ابھی دلی دور ہے) or its Persian version, *Hanuz Dehli dur ast* (هنوز دهلی دور است), literally meaning "Delhi is still far away", which is generically said about a task or journey still far from completion.[42][43]
- *Ās-pās barse, Dillī pānī tarse* (आस-पास बरसे, दिल्ली पानी तरसे / آس پاس برسے، دلی پانی ترسے), literally meaning "It pours all around, while Delhi lies parched". An allusion to the sometimes semi-arid climate of Delhi, it idiomatically refers to situations of deprivation when one is surrounded by plenty.[43]

The form *Delhi*, spelled in the Latin script with the *h* following the *l*, originated under colonial rule and is an alternation of the spelling based on the Urdu name of the city (دہلی, *Dehli*).[44]

History

Ancient and early medieval periods

The walls of the 16th-century Purana Qila built on a mound matching ancient literary descriptions[45]

Traditionally seven cities have been associated with the region of Delhi. The earliest, Indraprastha, is part of a literary description in the Sanskrit epic *Mahabharata* (composed c. 400 BCE to 300 CE but describing an earlier time[46]) which situates a city on a knoll on the banks of the river Yamuna. According to art historian Catherine B. Asher, the topographical description of the *Mahabharata* matches the area of Purana Qila, a 14th-century CE fort of the Delhi sultanate, but the analogy does not go much further. Whereas the *Mahabharata* speaks of a beautifully decorated city with surrounding fortifications, the excavations have yielded "uneven findings of painted grey pottery characteristic of the eleventh century BCE; no signs of a built environment, much less fortifications, have been revealed."[45]

The earliest architectural relics date back to the Maurya period (c. 300 BCE); in 1966, an inscription of the Mauryan Emperor Ashoka (273–235 BCE) was discovered near Srinivaspuri. Remains of several major cities can be found in Delhi. The first of these was in the southern part of present-day Delhi. Tomara Rajput King Anang Pal built the Lal Kot and several temples in 1052 CE. The Chauhan Rajputs under Vigraharaja IV conquered Lal Kot in the mid-12th century and renamed it Qila Rai Pithora.

Late medieval period

Prithviraj Chauhan was defeated in 1192 by Muhammad Ghori in the second battle of Tarain. Qutb-ud-din Aibak, was given the responsibility of governing the conquered territories of India after Ghori returned to his capital, Ghor. When Ghori died without an heir in 1206 CE, Qutb-ud-din assumed control of Ghori's Indian possessions and laid the foundation of the Delhi Sultanate and the Mamluk dynasty. He began construction of the Qutb Minar and Quwwat-al-Islam (Might of Islam) mosque, the earliest extant mosque in India. It was his successor, Iltutmish (1211–1236), who consolidated the conquest of northern India.[33][47] At 72.5 m (238 ft), the Qutb Minar, a UNESCO World Heritage Site in Delhi,[48] was completed during the reign of Sultan Illtutmish in the 13th century. Although its style has some similarities with the Jarkurgan minaret, it is more closely related to the Ghaznavid and Ghurid minarets of Central Asia[49] Razia, daughter of Iltutmish, became the Sultana of Delhi upon the former's death.

For the next three hundred years, Delhi was ruled by a succession of Turkic, Indian and an Afghan, Lodi dynasty. They built several forts and townships that are part of the seven cities of Delhi.[50] Delhi was a major centre of Sufism during this period.[51] The Mamluk Sultanate (Delhi) was overthrown in 1290 by Jalal ud din Firuz Khalji (1290–1320). Under the second Khalji ruler, Ala-ud-din Khalji, the Delhi sultanate extended its control south of the Narmada River in the Deccan. The

Historical affiliations

Kuru Kingdom c. 1200 BCE – c. 345 BCE
Nanda Empire c. 345 BCE – c. 322 BCE
Mauryan Empire c. 322 BCE – 185 BCE
Shunga Empire 185 BCE – 73 BCE
Sakas 1st century CE
Kushan Empire 30 CE – 375 CE
Gupta Empire c. 240 CE – c. 550 CE
Pushyabhuti dynasty c. 500 – c. 647 CE
Varman dynasty c. 725 – c. 770 CE
Pratihara dynasty c. 730 – 1036 CE
Chahamanas of Shakambhari c. 1036 – 1192 CE
Ghurid dynasty 1192 – 1206 CE
Delhi Sultanate 1206 – 1398 CE
Timurid Empire 1398 CE
Delhi Sultanate 1398 – 1526 CE
Mughal Empire 1526 – 1540 CE
Sur Empire 1540 – 1555 CE
Mughal Empire 1555 – 1737 CE
Maratha Empire influence 1737 CE
Afsharids 1738 – 1739 CE
Maratha Empire 1737 – 1803 CE
Durrani Empire 1757 CE
British East India Company 1803 – 1858 CE
India British India 1858 CE – 1947 CE
India 1947 CE – Present

Delhi sultanate reached its greatest extent during the reign of Muhammad bin Tughluq (1325–1351). In an attempt to bring the whole of the Deccan under control, he moved his capital to Daulatabad, Maharashtra in central India. However, by moving away from Delhi he lost control of the north and was forced to return to Delhi to restore order. The southern provinces then broke away. In the years following the reign of Firoz Shah Tughlaq (1351–1388), the Delhi Sultanate rapidly began to lose its hold over its northern provinces. Delhi was captured and sacked by Timur in 1398,[52] who massacred 100,000 captive civilians.[53] Delhi's decline continued under the Sayyid dynasty (1414–1451), until the sultanate was reduced to Delhi and its hinterland. Under the Afghan Lodi dynasty (1451–1526), the sultanate recovered control of Punjab and the Gangetic plain to once again achieve domination over Northern India. However, the recovery was short-lived and the sultanate was destroyed in 1526 by Babur, founder of the Mughal dynasty.

The Qutub Minar, Delhi

Early modern period

Red Fort, a UNESCO World Heritage Site, was the main residence of the Mughal emperors for nearly 200 years.

In 1526, Babur, a descendant of Genghis Khan and Timur from the Fergana Valley in modern-day Uzbekistan, invaded India and defeated the last Lodhi sultan in the First Battle of Panipat and founded the Mughal Empire that ruled from Delhi and Agra.[33] The Mughal dynasty ruled Delhi for more than three centuries, with a sixteen-year hiatus during the reigns of Sher Shah Suri and Hemu from 1540 to 1556.[54] Shah Jahan built the seventh city of Delhi that bears his name *Shahjahanabad*, which served as the capital of the Mughal Empire from 1638 and is today known as the *Old City* or *Old Delhi*.[55]

After the death of Aurangzeb in 1707, the Mughal Empire's influence declined rapidly as the Hindu Maratha Empire from Deccan Plateau rose to prominence.[56] In 1737, Maratha forces led by Baji Rao I sacked Delhi following their victory against the Mughals in the First Battle of Delhi. In 1739, the Mughal Empire lost the huge Battle of Karnal in less than three hours against the numerically outnumbered but militarily superior Persian army led by Nader Shah of Persia. After his invasion, he completely sacked and looted Delhi, carrying away immense wealth including the Peacock Throne, the Daria-i-Noor, and Koh-i-Noor. The Mughals, severely further weakened, could never overcome this crushing defeat and humiliation which also left the way open for more invaders to come, including eventually the British.[57][58][59] Nader eventually agreed to leave the city and India after forcing the Mughal emperor Muhammad Shah I to beg him for mercy and granting him the keys of the city and the royal treasury.[60] A treaty signed in 1752 made Marathas the protectors of the Mughal throne in Delhi.[61] The city was sacked again in 1757 by the forces of Ahmad Shah Durrani, although it was not annexed by the Afghan Empire and being its vassal state under the Mughal emperor. Then the Marathas battled and won control of Delhi from the Afghans.[62]

Colonial period

In 1803, during the Second Anglo-Maratha War, the forces of British East India Company defeated the Maratha forces in the Battle of Delhi.[63] During the Indian Rebellion of 1857, Delhi fell to the forces of East India Company after a bloody fight known as the Siege of Delhi. The city came under the direct control of the British Government in 1858. It was made a district province of the Punjab.[33] In 1911, it was announced that the capital of the British Indian Empire was to be transferred from Calcutta to Delhi.[64] This formally transferred on 12 December 1911.[65]

British India stamps, inauguration, New Delhi, February 1931

The name "New Delhi" was given in 1927, and the new capital was inaugurated on 13 February 1931. New Delhi was officially declared as the capital of the Union of India after the country gained independence on 15 August 1947.[66]